

The Dark Sides of DH revisited: From Utopia to Reality

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This panel takes up the concept of the “dark sides of DH”, which emerged as a disciplinary discourse about a decade ago (cf. Chun et al. 2016). However, we now adopt this once specific concept (originally “the dark side of DH”, singular) as a lens through which to examine current challenges facing the field. At the same time, we see the concerns we outline not just as important problems, but also as opportunities and new frontiers. They can therefore be reframed as the bright sides of DH, since we, as a field, are in a position to take positive and proactive action in response.

The question of what constitutes the “dark sides” of digital humanities (DH) has been widely debated, with neoliberalism initially identified as a central concern. The field’s alignment with neoliberal values was most forcefully articulated during a series of debates that followed Stephen Ramsay’s influential 2011 Modern Language Association (MLA) talk (Ramsay 2013), which gave rise to the well-known ‘Hack vs. Yack’ controversy (Nowviskie, 2014). This debate foregrounded tensions between technical practice and critical reflection in DH and prompted concerns about the field’s trajectory. By 2013 and 2014, panels at

the MLA began framing DH not merely as an academic development but as a potential neoliberal takeover of the humanities, suggesting that DH was contributing to the marginalisation of critique and reinforcing precarious labour structures (Chun, 2016): Richard Grusin argued that the field’s emphasis on making – as opposed to critical inquiry – mirrored the instrumental logic of neoliberalism, which tends to valorise technical skills while obscuring structural inequalities (Chun, 2016). These tensions reached a critical point with the 2016 publication of “Neoliberal Tools (and Archives)” by Allington, Brouillette, and Golumbia in the *Los Angeles Review of Books*. The authors denounced DH as complicit in the corporatisation of higher education, accusing it of fetishising data and producing intellectually shallow work. While the essay provoked considerable backlash, it nonetheless gave voice to widespread unease about DH’s institutional positioning and its perceived lack of sustained cultural critique.

The internal view of DH is often quite the opposite: that of a challenger of traditional norms somehow unaffected by structural issues that plague academia. The notion of vocational awe, first formulated by Ettarh and subsequently adapted to the context of DH by Melissa Terras (Borek et al., 2023), refers to the field’s often uncritical belief in its own intrinsic virtue. It is characterised by the assumption that those working within DH are inherently good and will therefore intuitively act ethically.

The persistence of concerns around the dark sides of DH to this day, even if the objects of critique have somewhat shifted, suggests that they are structural rather than incidental. As Smithies (2022) argues, DH is shaped by entrenched inequalities inherited from both Western academia and the technology industry – inequalities that cannot be corrected through symbolic or tokenistic measures. This panel, like Smithies (2022), urges DH to move beyond rhetorical commitments to inclusivity and instead integrate political and cultural critique into its technical and infrastructural practices. This includes, among other aspects, attention to meta-data representation, intellectual property, labour rights, and environmental sustainability – all of which are embedded in global systems of algorithmic bias, surveillance capitalism, and infrastructural inequality.

From a contemporary perspective, several pressing concerns remain unaddressed. These include the field’s insufficient engagement with (AI) ethics (Berry, 2022), persistent data gaps, language diversity (Spence & Brandao, 2021) and inclusion, as well as the marginalisation of feminist perspectives and feminised research topics – despite these offering conceptual resources for resolving many of the discipline’s structural issues. Additionally, the increasing dominance of computational approaches continues to displace other forms of scholarship, further reinforcing a narrow vision of what constitutes valid research in DH.

To this end, this panel aims to address some of these ubiquitous issues by juxtaposing multiple areas, including gender, as well as linguistic, environmental, and further social perspectives, which still constitute strongly under-represented aspects in digital humanities.

The purpose of the panel is to draw attention to specific areas which would need to be strengthened towards a more inclusive DH environment and digital research infrastructures. At the same time, we aim to achieve this not only by pinpointing the significance of certain challenges that a very high number of scholars engaged in (or wanting to engage in) digital scholarship are facing, but by taking a step further by inviting the audience to collectively think together about what the DH field could become through concerted efforts to mitigate systemic inequities – hence the title “utopia made real.” Since the abovementioned issues require the collective contribution of a broad range of stakeholders, we consider the combination of concise lightning talks and ample discussion during the panel particularly important. In order to showcase the complexities of the problems at hand, the session will also consider what the marginalization of these perspectives may entail and result in, encouraging a lively discussion regarding the layers of what the “dark sides of DH” might mean.

To discuss this issue, we have assembled a panel representing a range of perspectives from DHd working groups, each offering relevant insights on the topic. The panelists are:

- * Alíz Horváth for DARIAH Multilingual DH AG
- * Sarah Lang for DHd AG Empowerment
- * Jonas Müller-Laackmann as co-opted DHd board member for outreach and representation
- * Torsten Roeder for DHd AG Greening DH
- * and Matthias Arnold as moderator

Panelists

Alíz Horváth will briefly discuss the complexities of what the term multilingual DH refers to through her individual and data-driven collaborative research projects focusing on both conceptual perspectives on language inclusivity in digital scholarship (Spence, 2021; del Rio Riande, 2022; Dombrowski and Burns, 2023; Horváth et al. 2024), and more pragmatic considerations regarding its “users” through UX methods. Arguing for the need for a more multifaceted understanding of the realities of those involved in multilingual DH, she will also offer concrete examples of initiatives for enhanced language diversity between the DARIAH Multilingual DH Working Group, which she leads, and other like-minded communities in ADHO, the DHd, among others.

Sarah Lang will draw on her recent (and about to be published) work on using dataset audits to mitigate data gaps as well as the upcoming ZfdG Working Paper on Data Feminism coming out of the AG Empowerment. Both these initiatives provide practical approaches every DH project can implement without too much extra work to help move our community towards more equitable and inclusive data practices. Building on work from critical archival studies, she asks how existing initiatives can be used to make digital humanities work more ethical.

Jonas Müller Laackman will talk about his new co-opted role in the DHd board of directors which focuses on outreach and representation, meaning that certain disciplines and topics are underrepresented in the German DH landscape and we wonder why that is. He draws on existing studies of representation at digital humanities conferences (Eichmann-Kalwara et al., 2018) to begin exploring this topic and introduces an initiative that will examine disciplinary representation and review rejections in the DHd context.

Torsten Roeder will address the often narrow understanding of “sustainability” of the DH landscape. Current strategies are largely driven by efficiency, whereas concepts like sufficiency and consistency, well-established in environmental research, are rarely considered. The field’s inherent interest in digital technologies can lead to dependencies on commercial models and reinforce unsustainable practices, raising the question of whether DH bears a particular responsibility to foster ongoing critical discourse around these issues. Finally, while the ecological footprint of DH may be marginal, scientific practice is always an ethical choice, and sustainability should be an integral part of that ethical reflection. In the not too far future, could sustainability become a key to survival?

Schedule

To ensure enough time for discussion with the audience, we intend the input by the panelists to be very short (max. 10 minutes each, quick direct questions included). Additional material (as slides) will be published before the discussion and can be studied and referred to by the panelists and the audience, but will not be presented in detail, but only if the discussion requires it. After approximately 45 minutes of discussion, we will open the floor to the audience to encourage dialogue within the community about how we can best tackle these issues, together leaning into the bright-side potentials of our field.

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